

60bb13d3600k™ (Gobbledegook)

THE TECHNOLOGY INDUSTRY, like every other, isn't bereft of bullshit. On one hand you have the research centric domains where every term used is proper and indicative of a real world phenomenon. Then there is the marketing side which is hell bent on selling every aspect that doesn't need selling. An engineer wouldn't have seen the marketing potential of something as silly as contrast ratios. However, a marketer would pounce on the first inflatable statistic and come up with five different ways to use that statistic to their advantage.

I'm no fan of Apple but there isn't an example more relevant than the Cupertino giant. Most of Apple's product portfolio consisted of repackaged features that other tech companies had launched ages ago. Apple's contribution to it all? A marketing spin that puts all the other companies to shame. While in the short term these marketing tactics did earn Apple more money than they could handle, it also brought about a revolution of sorts as each and every tech company jumped on to the bandwagon. For example, take the App Store. Few know that the Electronic AppWrapper was the first "app store" to ever exist. It was demonstrated to Steve Jobs at a NeXTWorld EXPO back in the early '90s when the iPhone did not exist. Apple's App Store wouldn't come to be for a good 15 years.

The question is, is marketing really that necessary?

You didn't know about AppWrapper or the fact that it existed before Apple's App Store did. To top it all, every company in the smartphone business tried to build their own App Store and failed to achieve the same success with the exception of a few such as Google Play Store and Amazon Appstore. The app revolution happened because Apple knew how to market an existing thing really well. This resulted in an entirely new industry dedicated to developing apps. Kids as young as 9 have made apps and the entire industry was predicted to earn \$77 billion in 2017. That's how huge the impact of the app revolution has been.

On the other hand you have the fallacies that are touted as the next big thing. I say touted because their bullshit reeks from a mile away.

Some are caught before the product even goes to sale. For example, we regularly see renders from video game previews that are way better than the game will be when it launches. We call them "Bullshots" (bullshit screenshots). Then there are not so obvious ones like the 3.5+0.5 VRAM controversy with the 970 that were only caught after gamers noticed glitches during heavy usage. At the end, it turned out that the engineers were transparent about the memory issue while the marketing division went ahead and called it 4 GB anyways.

It might appear that marketers are the scum of the earth, and they are, but they also play an important role. In the enthusiast tech industry, we shouldn't let marketers have a free hand to do what they choose. In fact, the engineers can do a better job of bringing out actual statistics that matter, which makes the entire process more transparent and more competitive. Some might be quick to point out that the App Store revolution wouldn't have happened if engineers did what marketers do. With say a CPU, Engineers would want to talk about the multithreading aspects or the radical change to the cache hierarchy which have real world implications. While for the same thing marketers would slap on a different brand name, call it the "Platinum Amethyst standard" and come up with more gobbledegook. I'd much rather have the former than the latter because the latter tells me nothing.

This is why I like the PC tech industry. Companies spend 10-20% of their revenue back into R&D and come out with better products each year while the consumer tech industry spends way less in R&D and a lot more in marketing. The former forces the competition to spend more on R&D as well or they'd lose out on the technology race, thus, speeding up the rate of innovation. I don't see any reason why we shouldn't have it that way. What do you think? 



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